

SUMMER CAMP FUND

CEO donates \$100,000 to Observer's fund

Kenny Habul's gift is the largest ever for the fund

He's a solar energy company CEO and race car driver

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A solar energy company CEO who's also a race car driver has given \$100,000 to The Charlotte Observer's Summer Camp Fund.

It's the largest single donation in the fund's history. Kenny Habul said he hopes the money will help more kids from low-income families have a fun, healthy, summer camp experience.

"This is something exciting for us, something where we can see results," Habul said. "If we can put smiles on kids' faces, it is worth it to us."

As the annual fundraising campaign enters its

last week, Habul's donation pushes this year's tally to \$373,770, the most raised since the fund started in 2009.

Honorary fundraising chairman Rick Hendrick said early on that he



Habul

planned to call on his many associates to contribute, and they responded. From drivers on his NAS-CAR team, such as Dale Earnhardt Jr., Jimmie Johnson and Jeff Gordon, to racing and auto dealership workers to family and friends, Hendricks' people have donated generously.

Hendrick said he wants

to give as many children as possible an opportunity that could be a life-changer. Habul said Hendrick inspired him.

"He's someone I've always looked up to," Habul said.

Habul was born in Sydney, Australia, to parents who came there from Bosnia. He grew up in Queensland, went to law school and became a race car driver along the way.

He moved to Canada and then the United States. He and his wife, Kim, own SunEnergy1, a solar energy company based in Mooresville. He also drives part-time for Joe Gibbs Racing in the Xfinity Series (formerly the Nationwide Series).

The couple has three young children and is expecting a fourth.

Habul said he hopes to visit some of the camps to see the kids who will benefit from the scholarships.

"We've been very fortunate, and we try to help out where we can," he said. "We're thankful to Rick for opening our eyes to the need."

"Being a kid should mean being happy."

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